run our government on those principles," Kejriwal is shown saying earlier this year in a clip.

An astute politician and a sharp communicator, Kejriwal has been invoking Ram for some time now. Around three years ago, much before the Ram temple in Ayodhya was to be a reality, he had elaborated his idea of Ram Rajya in Delhi.

The AAP has been mindfully ambivalent about religion and mostly positioned itself as a welfarist, religion- and caste-agnostic party. But unlike many of his allies in the INDIA bloc, Kejriwal has been steadfastly unwilling to cede the Hindu nationalist narrative entirely to the BJP. He was among the first chief ministers to visit the Ram temple and offer prayers. He recites the Hanuman Chalisa and visits Delhi's iconic Hanuman Mandir often. Recently, his wife Sunita also offered puja there after Tihar Jail authorities allowed the CM access to insulin. A popular scheme of the Delhi government—the Mukhyamantri Tirth Yatra Yojana—has taken senior citizens to the Hindu pilgrimage centres of Haridwar, Puri, Kanyakumari, Dwarkadhish and Ayodhya. So far, 36,000 people have taken part in these government-sponsored trips.

The AAP's outreach this time goes beyond Delhi and Punjab—where it holds power—to include Gujarat, Goa and even Assam. The party has for long years been trying to craft a pan-India message that covers more than just hyper-local planks like free electricity, schools and neighbourhood clinics. "Through this website, we want to send the message to the people of India that, if they vote for the right party, their life will transform," says Atishi, AAP leader and Delhi minister. However, the party is quick to point out that their Ram Rajya vision is different from that of the BJP. "There are two ideas of the Ram Rajya. One is Gandhi's and the other is [Nathuram] Godse's," says AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj. "Ours is Gandhi's Ram Rajya, which advocates welfare and secularism."

Clearly, the AAP has devised its entire strategy to leverage Kejriwal's arrest in the Delhi excise policy scam. This has enabled Kejriwal to occupy a significant space in the political conversations in Delhi, which was absent in the previous two Lok Sabha polls.

Soon after being sent to Tihar Jail, Kejriwal is said to have sought three books to read. One of them was the Ramayana. The AAP would like to be known for its welfare schemes. But surely, a sprinkle of Ram on top of that philanthropy may help. ■

A 'MAHARAJA' SEEKS MAJORITY

A WADIYAR RIDES AGAIN—THE BJP HOPES TO MILK REVERENCE FOR OLD ROYALTY, EVEN AS YADUVEER SEEKS THE COMMON TOUCH. BUT THIS IS ALSO SIDDA'S HOMETOWN

By Ajay Sukumaran



MADHUSUDHAN SR

IN the Swachh Survekshan 2023—an annual cleanliness survey that's been conducted by the Union ministry of housing and urban affairs since 2016—Mysuru was ranked in 23rd position. The slot is quite a tumble for Karnataka's 'City of Palaces', which had been ajudged the cleanest in the country in the survey's inaugural edition and has since been consistently among the top eight cities. It's only logical to assume that the city would be eager to regain